

Seawall height in Boca Raton

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

BOCA RATON • PALM BEACH COUNTY

4.0 – 6.0 ft NAVD88

Boca Raton sets a band, not a single number. Any new or replaced seawall or dock must reach 4.0 ft NAVD88 and must not exceed 6.0 ft NAVD88. The requirement lives in the city's Engineering Design Standards Manual rather than the ordinance, which is why it is hard to find.

The detail

MINIMUM	4.0 ft NAVD88, for any new or replaced seawall or dock, publicly or privately owned.
MAXIMUM	6.0 ft NAVD88.
BUILD FOR MORE	Standard 3 requires the wall to be designed and constructed so a further 12 to 18 inches can be added later and the wall stays structurally sound without altering it.
WATCH THE DATUM	The city states its requirement in NAVD88. Contractor drawings in this area are sometimes written to MLW instead, and the two are not interchangeable. Ask which datum a quoted cap elevation refers to before you sign.
WHERE IT IS WRITTEN	Engineering Design Standards Manual section 7.7, Minimum Criteria for Waterway Features, updated January 2025. Chapter 22 of the Code of Ordinances covers marine structures generally.
INSPECTIONS	A zoning location survey must be approved before the cap goes on, and a final engineer report with the cap elevation and photographs is required after construction.

Where this comes from: City of Boca Raton Engineering Design Standards Manual § 7.7, Minimum Criteria for Waterway Features (updated January 2025); Code of Ordinances Ch. 22, Marine Structures

Verified: 2026-09. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1

Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2

Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3

Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4

Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.